

UNIVERSITY OF ESSEX

Postgraduate Examinations 2019

PROFESSIONAL PRACTICE AND RESEARCH METHODOLOGY

Time allowed: **TWO** hours

The following items are provided:

- OMR Form for answering multiple-choice questions
- Graph Paper (available on the invigilators desk)

Candidates are permitted to bring into the examination room:

Casio FX-83GT Plus or Casio FX-85GT Plus ONLY

The paper consists of **TWENTY ONE** questions. Candidates must answer **ALL** questions in **SECTION A** and **ALL** questions from **SECTION B**. Questions are **NOT** of equal weight.

Answers to **SECTION A** must be written on the machine-readable form.

Answers to **SECTION B** must be written in the answer book provided.

The percentages shown in brackets provide an indication of the proportion of the total marks for the **PAPER** which will be allocated.

Please do not leave your seat unless you are given permission by an invigilator.

Do not communicate in any way with any other candidate in the examination room.

Do not open the question paper until told to do so.

All answers must be written in the answer book(s) provided.

All rough work must be written in the answer book(s) provided. A line should be drawn through any rough work to indicate to the examiner that it is not part of the work to be marked.

At the end of the examination, remain seated until your answer book(s) have been collected and you have been told you may leave.

SECTION A is unavailable

SECTION B

Candidates must answer ALL questions in this section. Answers for questions in this section must be written in the answer book(s) provided.

Question 18

A firm has to choose between three possible projects where there is an initial capital cost (payable now) and forecasts for the net cash inflow at the end of each year for a 5 year period for each project. The details of each project are as follows:

Net cash inflow (£000)			
	Project A	Project B	Project C
Year 1	75	100	50
Year 2	125	200	75
Year 3	125	300	250
Year 4	100	300	300
Year 5	75	150	200

Capital cost	£000
Project A	300
Project B	500
Project C	300

Question 18 continues...

Question 18 (continued)

Assume an interest rate of 8%.

The formula for Net Present Value is:

$$\frac{X}{(1 + r)^t}$$

Where X is the amount to be adjusted, r is the interest rate as a fraction and t is the time period.

- a) Calculate the *Discount Factors* for each of the 5 years based on this interest rate. [5%]
- b) Calculate the total Discounted Cash Inflow for each of the projects across the 5 years. [6%]
- c) Based on these figures, which project is the most financially attractive? (Hint: you will need to compare the Net Present Value for each project taking into account the initial capital costs and the discounted cash inflow for each project). [4%]

Question 19

- a) List 5 differences between a limited company and a sole-trader. [5%]
- b) Explain what is meant by a company's gearing (or leverage) and give 3 examples of commonly used gearing ratios. [5%]
- c) Explain why a company with a high level of gearing might be considered to be more risky. [2%]

Question 20

- a) A student's assignment includes the following statement: ... [4%]

Tim Berners-Lee invented the World Wide Web.

Is a reference required for this information? Explain your answer.

- b) If you were summarising an article by another author, which 3 of the following types of information should be included in a summary, and which 2 should not? Explain your answer. [4%]

- A. Key points from the article
- B. The author's viewpoint
- C. Your viewpoint on the topic
- D. In-text referencing notes (for example a page reference for direct quotes)
- E. Your personal opinion on what you think about the article.

Question 20 continues....

Question 20 (continued)

- c) The followings is the original text from an article [4%]

For thousands of years, outsiders have regarded China as a xenophobic country. However, the stereotypes have been changing since China opened up its economy in 1979. Now, the encouragement of foreign direct investment (FDI) and international technology transfer (ITT) lies at the heart of economic relations between foreign countries and China. The international flows of capital, information and technology facilitate the economic growth of China and the influence of multinational enterprises (MNEs). The boom in FDI and ITT has brought to the fore the issue of intellectual property rights (IPRs) as a major topic in the economic development of China. Although a historical review shows that the germination of the concept of IPRs in China goes back more than 100 years, in reality no effective system of intellectual property protection (IPP) existed until very recent times.

Source: Yang and Clarke (2004, p.12).

Now comment on the following extract from a student assignment. Does it amount to plagiarism – or not? Explain your answer.

This essay is about intellectual property (IP) in general and about the situation in China today, and about China's relationship with the West in relation to this issue. For centuries China has been regarded by the outside world as a rather closed and xenophobic country. However things are changing. Since 1979, China has loosened and stimulated its economy by foreign direct investment (FDI), international technology transfer (ITT), and from the influence of multinational enterprises (MNEs). However, these developments have also focused attention on the issue of intellectual property rights (IPR) and until recently in China there has been no effective system of intellectual property protection (IPP).

Question 21

- a) When applying for a job, STAR provides a structure that can assist you in presenting examples as part of your written application or in an interview: The STAR categories are: Situation, Task, Action and Result. [4%]

The following are 4 statements. Decide which statement best matches against each of the STAR categories. A statement should only match to one of the STAR categories.

Statement 1:

I was responsible for collating, sorting and summarising the feedback from several feedback sessions of the consultation.

Statement 2:

My manager and director were both pleased with this work. My department was able to identify both positive and negative issues and key concerns, and work through them in progressing the new legislation.

Statement 3:

Our Department was conducting a consultation to determine people's views about a proposed change to legislation.

Statement 4:

First I ensured I understood exactly what the aims of the consultation were and the information my manager was seeking. I then developed a table for responses, themes, specific issues and comments. I could check back if any issue was queried. I grouped feedback themes and noted any issues and comments, such as related legislation. I was careful to work systematically through the feedback sheets so no important information was missed. When the feedback was collated and summarised, I presented the results to my manager and director.

Question 21 continues

Question 21 (continued)

- b) A covering letter for a job application normally contains the following types of statements: [6%]

1. Opening statements
2. Experience and qualifications
3. Reasons for applying
4. Closing statements

The following are separate statements which might be included in a covering letter as part of a job application.

- A. As you can see from my CV, ...
- B. Currently, I am working as a ...
- C. I am in charge of ...
- D. I am particularly interested in this position ...
- E. I am very keen to use my English ...
- F. I am writing in reply to your advertisement ...
- G. I have five years' experience in this sector.
- H. I look forward to hearing from you.
- I. I will be available for interview from ...
- J. I would be more than happy to discuss ...
- K. Please do not hesitate to contact me for ...
- L. With reference to your advertisement in ...

Each of the above examples match to only 1 of the statement types.

Which of the above could be considered an opening statement?

Which of the above could be describing experience and qualifications?

Which of the above could be describing the reasons for applying?

Which of the above could be considered a closing statement?

Use the statement numbers and the letters against each example to provide your answer to each of these questions.

END OF SECTION B

END OF PAPER CE902-7-FY